

Persona Development & Primary User Identification

Persona Development Guide

1. Why Personas Matter

A persona is a fictional, research-informed character that represents a cluster of real users who share similar goals, behaviors, and frustrations. Personas exist to answer one practical question during design:

"Whose problem are we actually solving, and what do they need to do?"

Once you know that, you can translate the persona's goals and pain points directly into tasks and features your product must support.

2. The Process (Step-by-Step)

Step 1 — Gather Raw Data

Before inventing a persona, ground it in something real: interviews or surveys, observations of current behavior, existing research, or competitor reviews. If real users are not accessible, base assumptions on realistic behavior and clearly label them as assumptions.

Step 2 — Identify Patterns

Look for recurring goals, behaviors, frustrations, and context across your data.

Step 3 — Group Into Segments

Cluster users into 2-4 distinct types, then choose a primary persona whose needs the product must satisfy above all others.

Step 4 — Build the Persona Profile

Use the template to make the persona concrete enough to design for.

Step 5 — Derive Tasks

For each goal or frustration, ask what feature or task would remove the friction. This becomes your task/feature backlog.

3. Persona Template

Field	Description
Name & Photo	A representative (not stereotypical) name/image
Tagline	One sentence capturing their core motivation
Demographics	Age, occupation/role, education, location
Tech Comfort	Low / Medium / High, and tools already used
Goals	What they want to achieve (2-4 items)
Frustrations	Current obstacles (2-4 items)
Behaviors	Habits, routines, current workarounds
A Day in Their Life	Short narrative showing when/where the need arises
Quote	A representative sentence in their voice
Tasks to Incorporate	Features derived directly from goals & frustrations

4. Worked Example — Aditi Rao, "The Juggling Junior"

Field	Detail
Age / Role	20, third-year Computer Science student
Tech Comfort	High — comfortable with apps, low patience for clutter
Goals	Track deadlines across 6 courses; balance study with a part-time job; avoid last-minute cramming
Frustrations	Deadlines scattered across email, LMS, and WhatsApp; forgets low-priority tasks until urgent; existing planners feel like overkill
Behaviors	Checks phone constantly between classes; relies on reminders over planning; prefers quick glance-and-go
A Day in Her Life	Between back-to-back lectures, Aditi has 5 minutes to check what's due. She needs a fast, trustworthy snapshot, not a detailed schedule.
Quote	"I don't need another to-do list — I need something that tells me what actually matters today."

Tasks to Incorporate (derived from persona):

1. Unified deadline dashboard — pulls assignments from multiple sources into one view
2. "Today" quick-glance view — surfaces only what's urgent
3. Low-effort quick-add — capture a task in under 10 seconds
4. Smart reminders — nudges before something becomes urgent
5. Priority auto-sorting — reduces manual planning

5. Quick Self-Check

- Is it based on patterns from real or realistic data, not a single individual?
- Does it avoid stereotypes and focus on goals/behaviors rather than surface traits?
- Can you point to at least 3 concrete tasks/features that trace back to this persona?
- Would a teammate unfamiliar with the project understand who they're designing for?

Example: Smart Tourism Application

Primary User Persona: Priya

Attribute	Description
Name	Priya
Age	28 years
Occupation	Software Engineer

Attribute	Description
Technology Usage	Frequently uses mobile applications
Goal	Plan and manage trips easily
Needs	Hotel booking, navigation, tourist information, personalized recommendations
Behaviour	Searches for destinations and compares hotels before travelling
Pain Points	Complicated navigation, difficulty finding important features, too many options
Expectation	Simple, fast, personalized, and easy-to-navigate application

Tasks Identified from the Persona

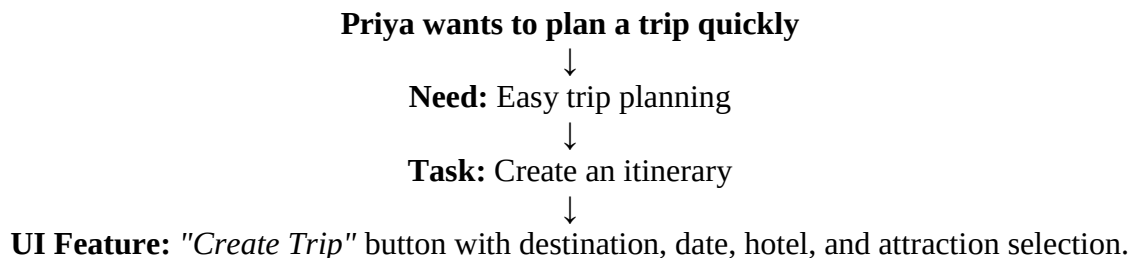
Based on Priya's needs, the following **user tasks** should be incorporated into the application:

1. **Search for tourist destinations**
2. **Plan an itinerary**
3. **Search and book hotels**
4. **Navigate to tourist attractions**
5. **View attraction details**
6. **Receive personalized recommendations**
7. **Check weather and travel information**
8. **Save favourite places**
9. **Modify or cancel bookings**
10. **View the complete trip plan**

Key Idea

Persona → User Needs → Goals → Tasks → UI Features

For example:



Thus, **developing a persona enables students to identify the primary users and systematically derive the tasks and UI features that should be incorporated into the system.**

How to incorporate pain points?

Use this flow:

Persona → Pain Point → User Need → Task → UI Solution

For the **Smart Tourism Application**, for example:

Pain Point	User Need	Task Identified	UI Feature/Solution
Difficult to navigate	Simple navigation	Find a destination/feature	Simple navigation menu
Important features are hard to find	Easy access to key functions	Book a hotel	Prominent “Book Hotel” option
Too many choices	Relevant information	Find suitable attractions	Search, filter and sort
Difficulty planning a complete trip	Convenient trip planning	Create itinerary	AI-based itinerary planner
Unclear directions	Easy navigation	Reach an attraction	Interactive map and directions
Generic recommendations	Personalized suggestions	Discover places	AI-based recommendations
Repeatedly entering information	Faster interaction	Make a booking	Saved traveller details
Uncertainty about bookings	Confirmation and tracking	Check booking status	Booking dashboard and notifications

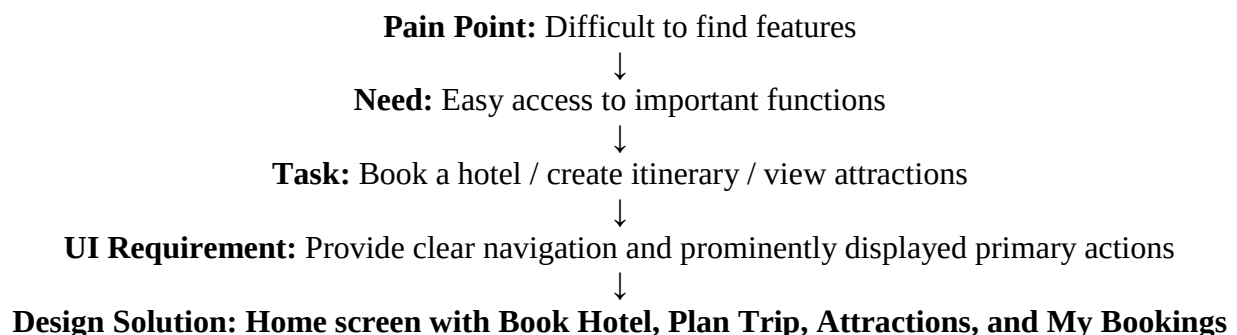
Example of incorporating a pain point

Suppose the persona says:

Pain Point: “I find it difficult to locate important features in tourism apps.”

Don't stop at mentioning the pain point.

Convert it into a design requirement:



Where should pain points appear in the persona?

A good persona can have a section like:

Pain Points

- Complicated navigation
- Important functions are difficult to locate
- Too many irrelevant recommendations
- Difficulty creating an itinerary
- Unclear booking and cancellation information

Then add a separate **“Persona-to-Task Mapping”** section to show how these pain points influence the tasks.

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